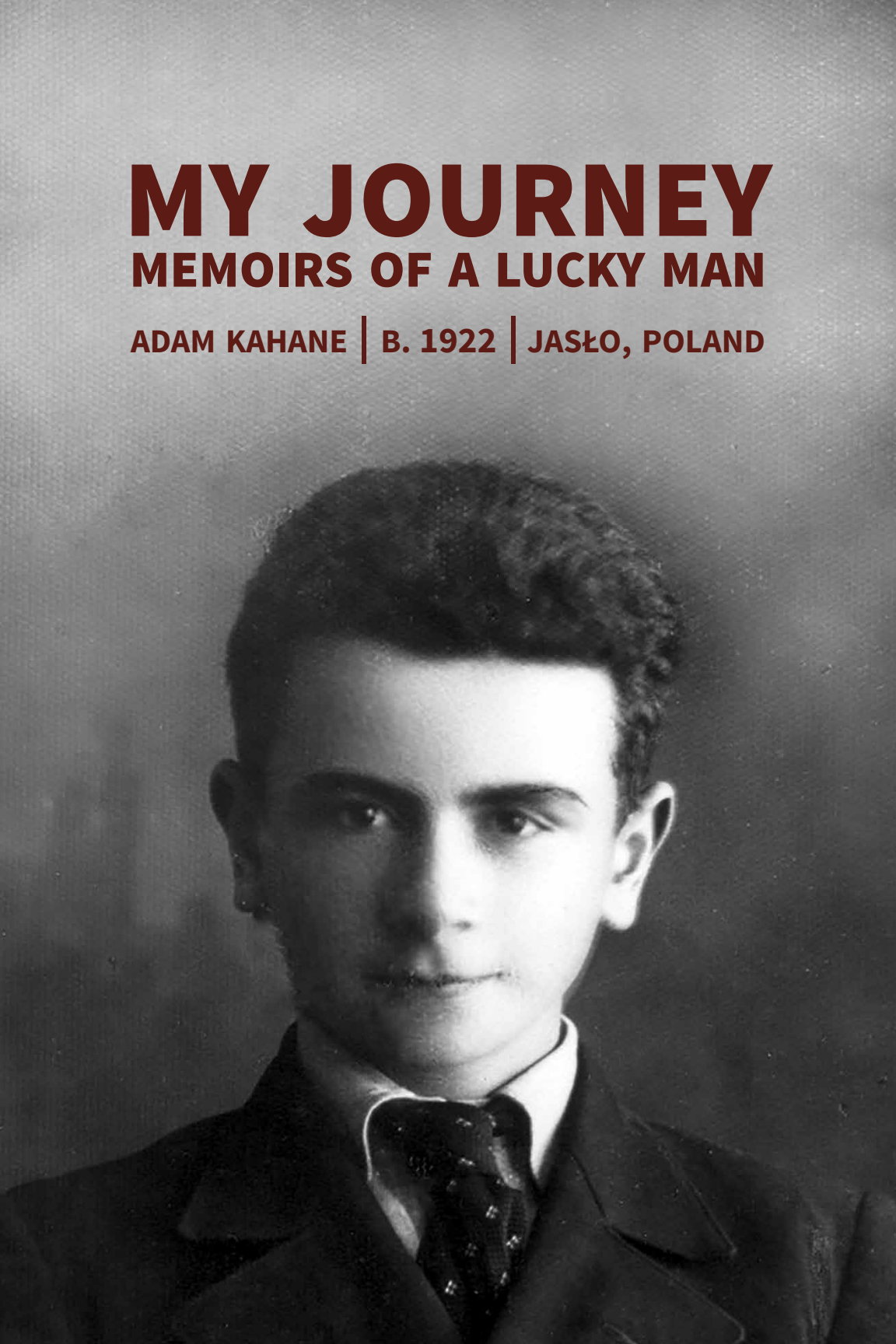
MY JOURNEY
MEMOIRS OF A LUCKY MAN

ADAM KAHANE | B. 1922 | JASŁO, POLAND



MY JOURNEY:
MEMOIRS OF A LUCKY MAN

12 YEARS OLD (1933)

33 YEARS OLD (1955)

90 YEARS OLD (2012)

ADAM KAHANE

JASŁO AFTER THE WAR

MY GRANDFATHER'S HOUSE (LIGHT RED ROOF) WHERE I LIVED BETWEEN THE AGES OF FIVE AND 17

CHILDHOOD AND YOUTH

I came to this world with a midwife's assistance on a warm July night of 1922, in an inn in Jareniówka on the left bank of Wisłoka River (Jasło was on the right side). My mother's sister, Manka, a gynecologist, was present, but did not interfere.

My mother traveled to Jasło, some 200 miles from Łodz, where she lived, to be with the family for the big event. She rented a place at the inn because she wanted privacy and fresh country air. Several months later, we returned to Łodz, where my father had a pharmacy and a small pharmaceutical lab. We lived there until I was five, when my mother divorced my father and we moved to Jasło to my grandfather's house.

Of the first five years of my life I remember only an incident, when I fired a cap pistol at my own face (I was clumsy even as a little child). The noise brought my mother to my room. I will never forget her worried, angry face. It was very uncharacteristic of her to show worry or anger. She truly believed that displaying emotions was somewhat vulgar. In this stage I was the only bright spot of her life. She was stuck in a loveless marriage, arranged by a marriage broker. She was four years older than my father and not very pretty. She knew that he married her because of her sizable dowry, which he needed to buy a pharmacy. They had nothing in common. She was an intellectual, with a Ph.D. in German literature, keenly interested in new ideas. Her idols were Goethe (she wrote a dissertation on his

MY UNCLES JULIUS AND WILLIAM, AND MY FATHER JACOB

writings), Freud, and Einstein.

My father Jacob was a rather conventional person, whose idea of fun was to have coffee or something stronger with his friends in the coffeehouse. He was ambitious. He wanted to have his own business and later started a successful lab, where he produced bases for ointments and facial creams. He had the good sense to get himself transferred from the Austrian army to the Polish Legion, whose officers ruled Poland between the wars. He was liked and respected by his friends and customers. After the war, I met a girl who lived in that neighborhood and she told me how popular he was.

My parents' divorce was quite amicable. My uncle Michał, who was a prominent attorney in Łodz, represented both of them. My father returned my mother's dowry (the pharmacy was quite profitable) and obligated himself to pay reasonable alimony.

My parents' divorce was a blessing for me because I exchanged the life of an only child in a dysfunctional family in a large industrial city for a life in a large close knit family in a pretty, small town full of aunts, uncles, and cousins.

REGGIE'S PARENTS HANKA & STASZEK WISTREICH

We shared the grandfather's house with the grandfather and the Wistreichs. Hanka, my mother's younger sister, married a lawyer, Staszek (Salomon) Wistreich, who managed grandfather's business. Actually, the official name of the business was: "Józef Menasse and Son-in-Law."

The store had a well deserved reputation for integrity and service. A sign on the wall proclaimed: "If you are satisfied, tell your friends. If not, tell us."

The Wistreichs had two children at that time: Ignacy Reginald (Ignac in Poland, Reggie in U.S.) and Eva. Hugo was born in 1930.

Reggie was five months older than me and we became inseparable for the next 25 years. We went together through kindergarten, elementary school, high school, nursing school in Kazakhstan, Banking School in Moscow, and Columbia University in New York City.

We complemented each other perfectly. Reggie was outgoing, laid back, sure of himself, but worked hard only when the situation required. I was somewhat introverted, but more ambitious and hardworking. If necessary, I could be outgoing, particularly in Reggie's company and later when dealing with customers and friends.

All in all, I believe that Reggie was more talented than me.

When we shared scarce food in Russia, each of us wanted the other to have more. We always had many friends, because many boys admired our unshakeable friendship.

We rarely argued, but sometimes we did. Not so long ago a family friend told me that he overheard me saying to Reggie when we were five years old: "I was brought by the stork, you came from your mother's ass." Reggie ignored it.

REGGIE, ADAM, EVA

ADAM, EVA, REGGIE, HUGO

My mother had a Ph.D. in German literature with minors in Latin and Greek. We were brought up on Greek mythology and German literature. Growing in such an environment gave us considerable advantage in school. My mother did not worry about our performance in school. She believed

that being a good athlete was as important as having good grades. We were the only boys in our school who had their own kayak, played tennis regularly in summer, and skied regularly in winter.

She dressed badly ("We do not have to impress anybody"). Once when I visited my father, he got very annoyed about the way I was dressed and bought me a new wardrobe, which I promptly discarded when I got home. I certainly did not want to look any different than Reggie.

My mother was an admirer of an American nutritionist named Hauser,

MY MOTHER'S PASSPORT PICTURE 1924

who almost 100 years ago preached that butter, milk, and eggs should be eaten in limited quantities (way before attention was paid to cholesterol).

On market day or perhaps more often, my mother and the cook would go

KAYAKING

to the market and bring baskets of berries and fruit. Our standard breakfast in summer was a plate of wild strawberries or blueberries with sour cream and a slice of bread.

During summer vacation we walked or biked every day to the riverbank, where until the age of five we ran around naked. At noon a store employee would bring us a hot lunch.

When we acquired the kayak, we would pick it up at Mr. Kramer's warehouse near the bridge over Jasiołka and paddle to the beach and sometimes up the river. Frequently, we made a fire and baked potatoes in the ashes.

On the other bank of the river were a meadow and a small grove. It was so pretty and peaceful there. Many years later, when I wanted to think about something relaxing, I thought about this place.

Every summer starting when we were 13, we took a kayak trip down some river, usually some 100 to 150 miles (Wisłoka, Wisła, Dniestr, and San). It was terrific fun. We slept in peasants' barns and bought food from them. On the first three trips we had a chaperone (on the first, the woodworking teacher who built our kayak, on the second and third, Wolek Jamner, a student of Lvov Polytechnical School). He was a very bright young man from a poor family, who was a protégé of our family. Once when we passed Lvov

on the way to Dniestr river, he took us to the student cafeteria. I remember how great the food tasted. Our food at home was healthy, but not very tasty (my mother made sure that our cooks were not great). She believed that rich children suffer more from eating too much than poor children for not eating enough. Wolek died tragically when the train in which he was being evacuated was bombed by German planes.

The most memorable trip was on the Dniestr River, which in some sections flows in a wooded canyon and at the time we paddled there, part of the river formed the border between Poland and Romania.

On the day before last we paddled late. It got dark, so when we saw light between the trees we beached the kayak and started walking toward that light. Suddenly, a black caped figure stepped out, told us to stop, and then asked us in a quite unfriendly tone, "What do you want?" We told him that we did not see any house for a while. It got dark and became dangerous to continue. We offered to pay for the night, but just to be sure we explained that this was the second to last day of our trip and we did not have much money left.

He put us up in the barn, but tied a mean looking dog at the door. We heard all kinds of noises during the night.

At 5am he woke us up and told us to beat it. When we got to the middle of the river, we started laughing hysterically because it was such a relief to get out of there.

A few miles down the river women were washing clothing. They told us that our host was a smuggler and a very dangerous man.

The kayak trips were a lot of fun. They also earned us respect of our classmates and contributed to our popularity.

In 1935 we took part in a sightseeing camp in the mountains. About 40 boys from all over Poland took part in the camp. We were the only Jewish boys and we were younger than most of the others. Two other boys from Jasło came with us, and both were sons of our mothers' childhood friends.

TOP: REGGIE, ADAM, RENATKA, LESIO
BOTTOM: JASIA, ROMEK (MICHAŁ'S SON), OLES, HUGO, ROMA, EVA
OF ALL OF THE CHILDREN SHOWN IN THIS PICTURE, I AM THE ONLY ONE LEFT (MOST DID NOT SURVIVE THE WAR)

Anyhow, we happened to be quite popular, because some other boys had never talked to a Jew, and we were kind of exotic. They found out that we are not different than them. It was a great lesson for all of us. We hiked in high mountains and took a boat trip through a picturesque gorge. I will never forget how good the food tasted particularly the dark bread with cheese in the morning.

THE FAMILY

The patriarch of our family Józef Menasse died in 1933 when I was 11 years old. He was widowed for 14 years.

I remember him as a gruff old man, who hardly ever spoke to his grandchildren. We knew that he loved us but rued the fact that all his children (except Uncle Tulus) got completely away from religion. He attended synagogue weekly and had a special seat there.

Obviously he was a good businessman because he built a very successful business specializing in quality textiles for suits and dresses—in those days only poor people bought ready-to-wear clothing.

His wife Regina, who died before I was born, was a strong woman, who probably married below her station when she married him. It was she who insisted that all their children receive university education. Old family photos show her as a pretty, dignified looking woman. Józef and Regina had seven children: four boys (Dulek, Mundek, Tulus, and Michał) and three girls (Giza, Manka, and Hanka).

DULEK

Uncle Dulek was handsome and a good athlete when he was young. He had a great sense of humor, always telling funny stories and singing funny songs. He practiced law in Jasło.

Before he got married, he managed to get his secretary pregnant. She gave birth in another town and I never met this cousin until after the war. He was brought up in a Catholic orphanage—a safe place for him to survive

MY FATHER JACOB AND MY UNCLE DULEK

the war, because he looked quite Jewish.

Dulek's wife Cyla was a teacher by education but she never taught. It was a dysfunctional marriage. They had two very talented children: Leos (Leszek) and Roma. Leos was our classmate, but we were not in his class—he was practically a genius. When he was 13 years old, he helped college students with math. He also wrote beautifully.

In 1940 Leos, who was not deported, entered Lvov Polytechnical. He was a top student there. In June 1941, he was brutally killed in the street by rioting Ukrainians. His misfortune was that he looked like a caricature of a Jew with a long, hooked nose.

Dulek stayed in Jasło during the war. When he was led to the station for the trip to Treblinka (annihilation camp) he reportedly waved to our teacher Mr. Grudniewicz, who was standing in front of his house and said, in Latin, "Ave Caesar, Morituri te salutant" (Hail Caesar, we who are about to die, salute you).

Cyla and Roma perished in Kołomyja where they were staying with family.

MUNDEK

Uncle Mundek was offered an engineering job in Sumatra (now Indonesia, then Dutch Indies) shortly after graduating from Polytechnical school. He became a prominent railroad builder—Leos told me there was a street in Palembang named after him.

After World War I, Mundek visited Jasło and lent a substantial amount of money to his father (my grandfather), which made it possible for him to rebuild his business that had been destroyed during the war, and provide substantial dowries for my mother and Aunt Hanka. During the first World War, Holland was neutral, and Dutch currency was very strong, so his money was very valuable.

Also on this trip, Mundek got himself a beautiful young wife, who accompanied him to Sumatra. They had one son named Kusiu. After his

MUNDEK MENASSE AT ENGINEERING SCHOOL
WITH FACULTY MEMBERS AND THEIR WIVES

MUNDEK MENASSE AS AN ENGINEER IN SUMATRA

retirement they lived in Vienna. When Austria was annexed they moved to Holland (he was a Dutch citizen), and from there they were eventually taken to Auschwitz.

MUNDEK MENASSE IN 1905 AS A HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATE

TULUS

Uncle Tulus was the grandfather's favorite, because he was the only one of the family who attended synagogue. He was a gentle and genuinely good person. His first wife came from the Zucker family (owners of Zarsyn brewery) and died of TB a couple of years after the wedding. His second wife was a sister of his first wife. Like Dulek, he practiced law in Jasło.

They had one son, Oles, who was about three years younger than me. During the war they were deported to a place in Siberia, where food was scarce, climate severe, and the work in mines very hard. When they were released in 1941, they decided to move to Central Asia. On the way Oles got typhus and died. Tulus died soon after from a broken heart; life without his only son lost its meaning for him.

His wife Pepcia and her sister Rozia survived the war and moved to Israel where we visited them. They were great cooks; Audrey and Stuart, my children, still remember their chicken cutlets.

MICHAŁ

Uncle Michał, the baby of the family, was the brightest of the Menasse children. He excelled in gimnazjum (European term for middle school), then

in law school, and had a flair for writing.

He married Mila Zajac, daughter of an industrialist from Sosnowiec, whose connections helped him in his career. All three Zajac girls were beautiful. One of Mila's sisters married one of the two Jewish senators in the Polish senate. The other married an estate owner (she and her husband converted to Catholicism long before the war). Uncle Dulek used to sing a little German song about Countess Melanie, implying that Mila was like a countess. She had a regal bearing but was an extremely nice and sweet person. Whenever she and Michał visited Jasło, they always brought gifts for the kids. Once they brought us a movie projector with couple of cartoons. It was a sensation for all of us including our friends.

When the war broke out, Michał moved to Jasło from Łodz, where he was practicing. He felt safer in Jasło. Somehow he believed that his older sister Manka, who was decorated by the German Army in World War I, could protect them. Also, he knew many people and had friends in Jasło.

When he was drafted in World War I, Manka got him a job at her hospital as officer's candidate, and there he survived the war in complete safety.

Early in 1940 Michał was visited by Mila's Catholic nephew, who offered to get Aryan papers for the family. Michał refused saying that he feels safe in Jaslo and could not live a life of lies.

I met this young man after the war. He looked like a Polish nobleman with a big mustache. He told me that Michał and his family were sent to Treblinka with Dulek. Several months before the deportation, they lived through the terrible tragedy of the murders of Aunt Manka, her husband Mundek Zucker, and their daughters Renatka and Jasia.

MANKA

Aunt Manka was a good doctor and a very stubborn person. This stubbornness may have cost the lives of her and Michał's families.

During World War I, Manka was a military doctor in the Austrian Army.

AUNT MANKA (LEFT), AUNT HANKA (RIGHT)

She saved the lives of a squad of German soldiers (Austria and Germany were allies) who were gassed on the Western Front.

She must have worked really hard to save these soldiers because she received citation for "outstanding service beyond duty" from the German general commanding that sector of the front.

She thought that with that citation she had nothing to fear from the Germans. She spoke the language perfectly, loved German culture, and believed that there is more to fear from the Russians than from the Germans. She even tried to talk Uncle Staszek into staying. To his credit, he did not listen to her.

Aunt Manka's house was right across the street from our gimnazjum and we always played bridge there, when excused from Catholic religion classes.

Manka was 8 years older than her husband Mundek Zucker (also a physician). Their marriage deteriorated and they divorced in 1937.

Mundek promptly started living with his pretty, but very primitive housekeeper.

When war broke out in 1939, Mundek Zucker fled to the Soviet zone, where he hooked up with a physician's widow and was not deported to the interior of the Soviet Union, like us.

Manka and Mundek had two lovely daughters: Renatka, who was one year older than us and Jasia, who was two years younger.

Renatka had a Catholic boyfriend who offered to marry her during the occupation, but she could not leave her mother and sister.

JASIA & RENATKA

When the war between Germany and Russia broke out in June 1941, Mundek and other Jasło refugees who were not deported to Russia found themselves in German occupied territory. Several months later, the Germans permitted the refugees to return home. A week after they returned, they were ordered to report to the police and were all arrested.

Even though Manka and Mundek were divorced, she decided to intervene on his behalf. When she did, she was promptly arrested and then shot. I guess the head of the Gestapo had it in for her because of her somewhat privileged position (she still lived in her house, where two Army officers were quartered and probably was not humble). When she was led to the execution place, she cursed the executioners and told them that they will pay for it.

Mundek was beaten to death at the Gestapo. The girls were ordered to get into a car and were taken to a small town near Jasło. There they were ordered to get out and push the car. The Gestapo men shot them from behind and let them die in the ditch.

Jasia lived another two hours (local Jews tried to help her). Renatka died instantly. Renatka was 21 and Jasia was 18.

I read the story of their execution in a survivor's report which I translated for the Holocaust Museum.

This is a horrible story, which hit me very hard because we were very close with Renatka and Jasia.

STASZEK, REGGIE, AND HANKA C. 1926

STASZEK & HANKA C. 1960

HANKA

Aunt Hanka was a very outspoken and spontaneous person, who loved sports.. In winter, she always led us kids on skis to a valley nearby. We followed her single file; on the way back we sometimes hitched a ride behind

peasants' sleds.

She was one of the founders of the "Library of Jewish Women," which had several thousand books and where I was a faithful customer. She was also active in other organizations. To me she was like a second mother. She made absolutely no difference between me and her children.

Uncle Staszek, Hanka's husband, was a wise and patient person with great integrity. He was widely respected. In the election to town council, he got the largest number of votes. He graduated from law school, but never practiced law. When he married Hanka he became the manager of grandfather's business.

He was president of "Merchants Bank" which proved to be quite handy when war broke out. He also treated me as one of his children.

GIZA

And now my mother, Giza. I wrote about her in the chapter about basic facts but I have more to tell.

I was often embarrassed by my mother because she was so unlike mothers of our friends. Her ideas about nutrition seemed so odd to "normal" people.

When we were walking to the river bank, we always passed near a field of spinach, which my mother encouraged us to eat. As a matter of fact, when I was about 15 years old, Uncle Michał, who handled my parents divorce (he represented both of them) said to me: "It was inevitable—alcohol and raw spinach do not mix" (My father liked to have a drink every day).

All Menasses were somewhat eccentric, but my mother beat them all. However, she got along with people very well, and was a keen judge of character. I learned to appreciate her when I got much older. When she was 80, she got sick with the flu. She was dozing, then woke up and said quietly to the visiting neighbor, "So that is how we die," and then she died.

MY MOTHER IN HER 60S

Nr.3895

Dominus GISELA M E N A S S E

oriundus JASLO in Galicia

nodis

Doctor P H I L O S O P H I A E

renuntiatus est.

Cracoviae 25 mensis Januarii anni 1912

Rector Decanus Promotor

SZAJNOCHA m.p. J.MICHOLNIKOW m.p. O.CHRISBACH m.p.

SEKRETARIAT UNIW. JAGIELL. w KRAKOWIE

Stwierdzam zgodność niniejszego wypisu z oryginałem.

W Krakowie, dnia 20 maja 1947 r.

HER PH.D CERTIFICATE 1912

MY MOTHER & ME

EVA AND HUGO—MY FIRST COUSINS

Eva was two years younger than me and Reggie. She was a pretty and friendly girl. Unfortunately, she got less attention than Reggie and me, which may have affected her later in life. She married Guy Feniger, a patent engineer in Paris. Hanka met Guy's mother at a Jewish organization in Paris, and one thing led to another.

Guy's father Samuel was a rarity—a Jew in Poland's diplomatic service, who served as Polish consul in Berlin. He was a protege of count Potocki , who

GUY, EVA, AND ME IN PARIS

RENEE, GUY, GEORGES, EVA 1961

was a sort of protector of Jews living in the town named after his family. He took a liking to a bright Jewish boy and paid for his education through law school. After the war, count Potocki became Minister of Foreign Affairs, and offered the young Feniger a job in the Polish embassy in Berlin. By the time the count retired, the young lawyer became indispensable in the embassy, staffed mostly by young aristocrats, who were not interested in hard work. He died in 1935, but the family continued to live in Berlin. In 1938, they moved to France, where they survived the war.

Guy finished a German high school and completed his engineering studies in Danzig (Gdansk)—a free German speaking city before the war. Eva and Guy had two children: Georges and Renee. Georges is a businessman in Paris. Renee teaches English in Normandy where her husband is a school principal. See photo of Georges and family on next page.

HUGO

Hugo was born in 1930. He was only nine years old when we left Jasło. I remember him as a very good looking, golden haired child. He was the baby of the family and everybody doted on him. He loved to be a passenger in our kayak when Reggie and I were paddling.

Eventually, he got a Ph.D. from Rutgers in food technology and held high

MY ONLY SURVIVING COUSIN GEORGES FENIGER AND HIS FAMILY. THEY LIVE IN PARIS. HE VISITS ME EVERY YEAR AND I FEEL VERY CLOSE TO HIM. CLAIRE IS NOW A PRETTY TEENAGER.

positions in the food industry, but the best thing he ever did was to marry Lucy—a very charming person, whom everybody in the family admired.

They had three children: David, a computer specialist, Diane, a CPA, and Matthew, a senior home manager.

AND NOW A BRIEF ADDENDUM ABOUT MY COUSIN-BROTHER

CARL, STACY, MARGO, NICOLE WISTREICH

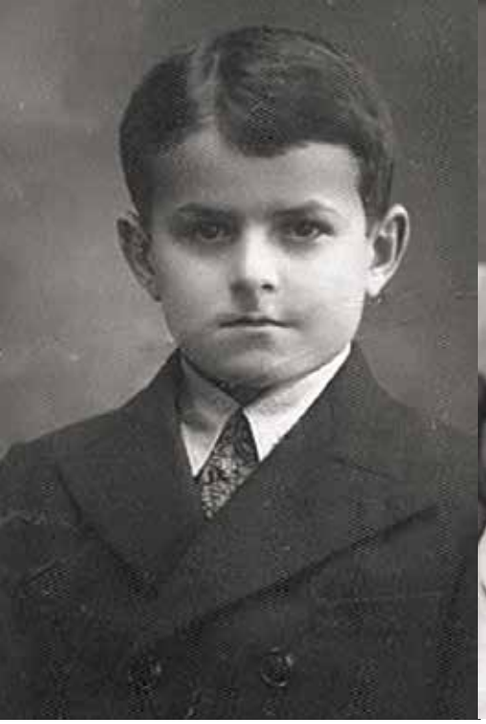
HUGO, ME, AND REGGIE

REGGIE

After graduation from college, Reggie stayed in New York where he worked for many years for a textile wholesale firm. His wife Margo was probably even more efficient than Gert. She was a good wife and was very attached to him.

They had three children: Stacy, a nurse practitioner in Los Angeles, Nicki, a teacher in upstate New York, and Carl, a successful lawyer, executive, and businessman in New Hampshire.

Reggie and I were in constant contact by phone. We also frequently skied together, took vacations together, etc. When Reggie died at almost 75, I felt that a part of me died with him.



REGGIE AT 8 AND AT HIS PRIME

ME IN 1934

SCHOOLS

There were two elementary schools in Jasło: One (Traugut) was attended by children of middle and upper class parents; the other one (Staszyc) by mostly poor children. Both schools were approximately the same distance from our house and both had good teaching staff.

My mother decided that going to school with poor children would be a good experience for us and we registered at Staszyc.

We were encouraged to make friends with poor children. There were two brothers in our class. One was a couple of years older because he had to repeat two classes. Once, on the way to a sledding hill, we decided to stop at their place and ask them to join us.

Their whole family lived in a basement room. In the corner stood a bed on which an older brother, an ex convict, emaciated from TB, was resting. There was an overpowering stench in the room.

We left as quickly as we came, but it was a good les-

son—some people do not live like us. That's why for lunch we always had only a roll with tomato, so the poor children would not get jealous.

Corporal punishment was rare, but still occasionally used. I remember when our teacher Mrs. Nowicka decided to smack a boy next to me with a ruler. He ducked and I got a good smack on the arm. She apologized to me and my neighbor got two smacks (one for ducking).

In elementary school I was usually appointed head of the class.

Every day in that public school started with a prayer. This made us realize that we were different and really did not belong.

There was some social experimentation in our school. Once, in third grade, we were told to elect a court, which was to decide on a punishment of any wrongdoer.

We could not figure out who is a wrongdoer. Finally, one of the boys said, "Bartek went to the bushes with a girl yesterday." That was a dilemma—why did he go there and what did he do there? It was somewhat over our

eight year old heads. Well, that was the first and last session of the court. Bartek the wrongdoer was very proud of himself—that is until his father found out.

After six years of elementary school we passed the entrance examination and were admitted to gimnazjum where we were to spend four years followed by two years of lyceum (high school).

About 600 boys attended the combined schools. We wore uniforms with the number of our school sewn on the sleeve.

Like in all European high schools, the discipline was strict and homework heavy. The teachers were addressed as "Professors," and were feared because one F meant repeating the class for another year. About 10–15% of boys had to repeat classes.

The first part of the class period was usually devoted to questions about the homework and the preceding class lesson. It was a moment of fear, when the teacher took out his black book and started pondering whom to call. Is

JASŁO BOYS' HIGH SCHOOL (REBUILT AFTER THE WAR)

MY HIGH SCHOOL PHOTO

he going for the beginning of the alphabet, middle, or end? The tension was heavy. Luckily, the least bright boys were most frequently called. A wrong answer would mean not only a failing grade, but often a dose of ridicule.

We were not allowed to see movies that had not been approved by the principal. Sometimes we dressed in civilian clothes (normally we wore uniforms) and snuck into one of the two movie houses in town. The movie houses were monitored by teachers. One of the most frequent monitors was professor Bagan—the only bachelor teacher. He pretended not to see us.

There were four Jewish boys in our class: "The family" and another boy. I was usually elected deputy head of the class (Reggie was too laid back and Leos too much of a geek and a lousy athlete). Anyhow, I was the only Jewish deputy head of class in our school, which later proved to be my undoing.

Among our teachers were three unmarried ladies—none of them pretty.

One of them definitely had a crush on me (she praised my mediocre compositions too profusely). Another one, who did not teach our class, had a nice figure and played good tennis. She shocked the town by getting herself impregnated by a student. She lost her job and moved to another town, but was not prosecuted because even in Catholic Poland, this was no crime.

The only bachelor among our teachers was professor Bagan—our history teacher and a great guy.

He entrusted me with biweekly reports about the international situation. I still remember how he cringed when I presented the events from a somewhat liberal viewpoint—favoring the republican side in the Spanish Civil War. The Polish press generally sided with General Franco, a good Catholic, who was also helped by Hitler and Mussolini. I am sure that Professor Bagan secretly shared my views.

Anyhow, in 1939 when our good friend Zdzisek Sopinski (head of class) and I (deputy head and main instigator) received "unsatisfactory behavior" marks on our report cards (which was equivalent to expulsion), Professor Bagan met me in Mundek Zucker's office (he was his patient).

He told me to not worry because the Teacher's Council decided that we will be readmitted in September and the expulsion was meant to spoil our vacation.

Actually this became immaterial because in September, war broke out and we never went back to that school. We received the "unsatisfactory behavior" marks for organizing a strike against a very unpopular teacher of physical education and military preparedness. He was a bigoted martinet disliked by most teachers.

Our role in organizing the strike was discovered when one of our classmates was overheard by his very religious landlady boasting how we got away with it. She reported it to the school priest, who reported it to the principal.

Zdzisek Sopinski had a crush on our cousin Jasia Zucker, which she not

MY FRIENDS AND ME CROSS COUNTRY SKIING IN A FOREST NEAR JASŁO

only did not reciprocate, but mocked him good-naturedly about his large head.

MY LOVE LIFE DURING HIGH SCHOOL YEARS

Very, very few boys in our school had girlfriends. One of the main reasons was that our school was for boys only and we had little social contact with girls. Not that they were not constantly on our minds. We spend a lot of time at Aunt Manka's house, which was across the street from school. Our cousin Renatka did not look down on us because we were a year younger and we were quite comfortable chatting with her and her best friend Hala. One summer afternoon Hala suggested to me that we could take a walk to Monastery Hill, where we found a bench shaded by chestnut trees. After a minute of silence, Hala said, "Adasiu," (endearing for Adam), "you can kiss me, if you want." I complied without hesitation, but somewhat awkwardly. My attempts to proceed beyond kissing met firm resistance.

SKI TRIP TO A FORMERLY GERMAN SKI RESORT AFTER THE WAR

A few days later we left for a kayak trip, followed by a summer visit to my grandparents. While there, I received several letters from her, which I answered without excessive enthusiasm. I was not quite comfortable with an older girl, who could involve me in conflicts with older boys who were interested in her, and besides, I had a preference for blondes.

Anyhow, during that summer visit to my grandparents, I started dating Marta, the local doctor's daughter, who was exactly my age. Occasionally, I accompanied her father when he visited his patients on his motorcycle.

Back in Jasło we still did not have any girlfriends. Kayaking, tennis, and skiing kept us busy.

VISITING FATHER AND GRANDFATHER

As I mentioned, my father lived in Łodz—a large industrial city about 200

miles from Jasło. I started visiting him when I was 10 or 11 years old. The first trip was memorable. My mother instructed me about train changes (three changes were required), gave me some money for emergencies, and off I went.

I successfully negotiated all the changes, but when I got to Łodz, nobody was waiting for me. I waited, and then took a taxi to my father's apartment. When I was ready to ring the bell, I heard the shrill voice of a woman. I got scared, went back to the street, and took a taxi to Uncle Michał's place (about a mile away). I rang the bell and when aunt Mila opened the door I burst out crying. I guess I was relieved that my odyssey was over.

Uncle Julek, my father's brother, was waiting for me at another Łodz station (there were two stations in Łodz), The woman with the shrill voice was my father's housekeeper. Actually, she was quite nice. Every morning she asked me what I would like for lunch and dinner. She was a great cook, but not the kind my mother would approve of.

There was not much for me to do in Łodz. Sometimes I would take the streetcar to my father's pharmacy and watch the pharmacists mix the ingredients of medicines.

Sometimes my father would take me to his favorite café, where he spent some time almost every day, and introduce me to his friends as "successor to the throne." He was actually very proud of me.

One Easter vacation, Reggie came with me to Łodz and we had a great time riding the streetcars, walking the streets of the big city and enjoying the good cooking of my father's housekeeper and Uncle Michał's cook.

I never had father and son talks with my father. He loved me, but we lived in different worlds. From time to time, my father had friends for supper. On such days, I had dinner in my room, but would join the company for a few minutes. His best friends were Major Bricki, a military lawyer, and Counselor Neiman. All of his friends were bachelors or divorced, and there were never any ladies present. I had reasons to suspect that some if not all of them were Catholic converts (Counselor Neiman's brother was

ambassador to Sweden. He would not be holding such a job if he did not convert. Probably he was also a former legionnaire).

My father stayed in Łodz during the occupation. Luckily his pharmacy was in the area designated as ghetto and he operated it almost to the time of the final liquidation of the ghetto. I was told by an Auschwitz survivor that he died of a heart attack on the train to the death camp. He was only 54.

My paternal grandparents had five sons: four were bachelors and my father was divorced. I was the only grandchild. One of my father's brothers (Julek) was a physician. He was very handsome (my mother told me that a young heiress killed herself because of unrequited love). He had a manservant (the only person I ever knew who had a manservant). He had an elegant apartment in a very modern building, which I loved to visit. At the age of 40 he died of appendicitis.

I inherited a cavalry officer's uniform and high boots from him (he was a reserve officer in a medical facility attached to a cavalry brigade), which I donated to the drama club in school. Next was Uncle Wilus who was in the

UNCLE JÓSEF, HIS WIFE HANIA, GERT, & ME. KRAKOW 1976

import business. During the war he fled to Yugoslavia. He perished either there or on a ship to Palestine which sank.

Uncle Iziu was a pharmacist who worked for my father. When the war broke out, he fled to Grzymalow where his parents lived.

He and Uncle Józef, who ran the grandfather's store, were hidden for almost two years in the home of Józef's friend (and presumably mistress), whose husband operated a flour mill.

On the day when Grzymalow was liberated, the husband died in a mill accident. Uncle Józef felt it was his duty to marry the woman, who saved their lives. He adopted her children and never emigrated from Poland.

During the several last years of his life I sent him money (that was when the dollar was king) and parcels. He died at the age of 70 as a result of an accident.

I saw him when I visited Poland in 1976 and later arranged for him and his wife a trip to Vienna, where they met with Uncle Iziu and Klara.

Uncle Iziu took over the pharmacy after the war, but when I returned from Russia, he ceded it to me and ran it for me for a while. Soon after the war he married Klara, also a pharmacist, who was his second cousin.

Klara graduated from Pharmacy school in Vilno (my father arranged for her admission) and married a physician, who practiced with his father in a small town near the Soviet border. Her father, brother, and father-in-law perished in the first "action" of the German occupation. Klara's husband practiced in the ghetto. When the situation got critical (they learned about impending "liquidation action") they decided to flee to the forests and join the partisans.

They found out about it from Oswald Rufeisen, a Bielsko Jew, who masqueraded as a Volksdeutsche (ethnic German) who spoke fluent German. He worked for the commander of criminal police as an interpreter and translator. Some time later, he was betrayed by a Jew, who hoped to save himself and his family (he was shot anyhow). The police commander,

EVA, IZIU, KLARA, ROZIA BOBA IN ISRAEL 1987

genuinely liked his interpreter, so after dinner, he told him that he has to put him in jail. However, he did not lock the jail, and let him escape to the forest, where he joined the partisans first and later found shelter in a monastery. After the war, Rufeisen converted to Catholicism and later became a Catholic priest. Eventually, he was sent to Jerusalem where he ran the German House, and eventually died.

Klara and her husband made arrangements with a Christian woman, who was to keep their three year old child. In the last moment, the woman changed her mind, because she did not realize that the child was circumcised. Since they could not take the child with them, they decided to commit suicide. He injected them all with a fatal dose of morphine, but Klara did not die (perhaps he planned it that way). She later joined the partisans. It was not easy for a young, pretty, and educated woman to live with the partisans. They were a rough bunch that was constantly on the move. After the war, she worked in the pharmacy, married Iziu, and later they emigrated to Israel.

ANNUAL SUMMER TRIPS TO GRZYMALOW

Every summer from age 11 to 18, I visited my paternal grandparents for a few weeks. The trip involved two changes of trains. Before the last change I always had time to have my favorite borscht with dumplings in a restaurant where the waiters looked suspiciously at the kid ordering lunch for himself.

SIMON KAHANE, MY PATERNAL GRANDFATHER, 1943, JUST BEFORE DEPORTATION

The train for that last section consisted of one passenger car and one freight car. I loved to stand on the platform and watch the quiet, rural scenery pass slowly by.

At Grzymalow station a "doroshka" hired by my uncle was waiting for me. We passed a pretty grove and when we got to town and passed by the doctor's house there was always my friend Marta waving from the garden. There was nobody for her to date there and vice versa for me.

My grandparents showered me with love and were very proud of me—their only grandson. Uncle Iziu showed me a snapshot of them taken shortly before deportation to the death camp. They have such fear and sadness in their eyes. I will never forget this picture.

SERVANTS, STORE EMPLOYEES, AND CARS

We had a full time cook, who also cooked for store employees and a cleaning woman who also did the laundry.

When Reggie, Eva, and I were little, we had a nanny—a very kind young woman— who gave us a lot of love. Later Hugo had a nanny—a pretty

Jewish girl who was generous with her charms (I was one of the beneficiaries, who never crossed the borders).

The cooks usually lasted 3–4 years. Some of them were real characters.

We had one cook—a rather bizarre looking woman— who on her day off would get garishly dressed, put makeup on her face, look in the mirror, and declare, "I am Miss Polonia de Francais."

Another one was a former housekeeper for two priests. From her remarks it was easy to conclude that she provided the good fathers with perhaps more than cooking. She was transferred to Uncle Michał's household in Łodz. She was probably transferred out of concern for Reggie's and my virtue. One of our last cooks talked to herself. She did not last long because she was too good a cook. Once she made some absolutely delicious croquettes, which Reggie consumed in much too excessive quantity. He got convulsions and Uncle Staszek had to take him to a specialist in Krakow, who assured him Reggie will grow out of it.

STORE EMPLOYEES

Store employees were usually Jewish boys from small towns or villages. When they were hired, their names were changed. Moyshe became Marek, Shiya became Olek, and Duvyd became Dudek, etc. They received room and board and slept in a room next to the store.

Once around 1925, one of our salesmen was caught stealing. Rather than prosecute him, he was encouraged to emigrate to the United States. Reggie and I visited him in Brooklyn (we had his address from a care package he sent to our folks in Paris). He had a small clothing factory and was president of a small congregation in Brooklyn. He sold us (presumably at wholesale price) two striped suits, favored at the time by Jewish and Italian gangsters. We never heard the end of it from Victor, a friend of old standing.

Most of our employees perished under German occupation. One of them

(Dudek) died tragically in Russia. Since he was "single", he was sent to the Gulag, not to a special settlement like us. After his release, he traveled to Uzbekistan where he got a job in a soap factory. He was caught stealing a piece of soap and was sentenced to three years. He was still quite weak as a result of the first imprisonment and died shortly after. I am telling you about him because I want you to realize that many refugees were not as lucky as us and quite a few died in the Soviet Union.

CARS

Only Aunt Manka and her husband, Mundek (both physicians) had cars. Mundek had a Ford model T, which he drove himself while Manka had a Czech made convertible. She had a driver, a Jewish boy of our age named Julek, who would often take us for rides. Her car was garaged in our yard, part of which was covered.

Julek survived the war in Russia and later emigrated to the U.S.

We met him in the United States when Victor's first and greatly beloved "motor car" expired (he inherited some $1000 and spent some of it on a used car). We had a great summer using that car until November, when the engine block cracked. Victor did not realize that in winter, cars need antifreeze.

It was Julek who pronounced the premature passing of this great machine (he was working as a mechanic at that time).

Later Julek went into the delicatessen business and became "Delicatessen King of New Jersey." Reggie visited him a couple of times, returning home with all kinds of delicacies.

DEPORTATION TO INTERIOR OF SOVIET UNION

As I mentioned in the "Childhood and Youth—Basic Facts" above, in early September 1939, our family fled to Gliniany, where a friend of Uncle Staszek owned an estate.

In late September 1939, we moved from Gliniany to Lvov for two reasons: first, it was not safe to be associated with an estate owner (certainly not a social class favored by Soviet authorities) and second because we (Reggie, Eva, Hugo, and I) had to continue in school.

Materially, we were actually quite well off. As I mentioned, Uncle Staszek was president of Merchants Bank (A small bank for Jewish merchants) and as such was able to get a freight car for evacuation of bank records. The stationmaster was an old friend and did not mind to oblige for a gift. Since the bank records hardly took any space, a substantial quantity of fabrics were loaded in the car, which was sent to Gliniany, where the family was staying. Some of the merchandise was sold, some given to friends and relatives, and some we kept. In the Soviet Union, high quality fabrics for suits and dresses were very valuable. These fabrics helped the family to survive the five years in the Soviet Union.

In Lvov, Reggie and I were accepted to "gimnazjum #10" and that was the beginning of a great year. The discipline was loose. The teachers did

not care very much and neither did we. Instruction was in Polish but we also studied Russian and occasionally Ukrainian. Nobody bothered about homework.

We made some great friends in that school—there were many refugees from Western Poland, with whom we had plenty in common. Everybody was uprooted—we had the advantage because there were two of us. Alex Lauterbach is the only other survivor of our high school class in Lvov. However, shortly before graduation, his family managed to leave Lvov and traveled to the U.S. through Japan. He served in the American army. We met after the war, and resumed our friendship. He participated in Polish/Jewish dialogue, and engaged in philanthropic activities and was recognized as Amicus Poloniae (Friend of Poland) by the Polish government.

The dreaded "matura" (comprehensive high school graduation exam) was a joke. We graduated with honors. The Honors Certificates were given to us at the graduation banquet, to which girls from girls' gimnazjum were invited. I met a very pretty Ukrainian girl, who was impressed with the applause Reggie and I got when we were handed the certificates.

ALEX LAUTERBACH IN 1945

We made a date for the following weekend, but by then I was traveling in a freight car to an unknown destination. I am sure she understood, anyhow, she was too pretty to worry about being stood up.

Hundreds of thousands of refugees from Western Poland lived in the area occupied by the Soviet Union on the basis of Stalin-Ribbentrop pact. About 90% of them were Jewish. Most of them were already in the area when Soviet troops arrived. A few slipped through the border later.

The Soviet authorities did not quite know what to do with them. It was impossible to check their backgrounds and the authorities were concerned there could have been many spies among them. Finally, in June 1940, the authorities decided that the refugees will be removed from the border zone and resettled in the interior of the Soviet Union. The families were moved to special settlements—usually in forests. Most of the "single" men were arrested and sent to Gulag camps, because they could possibly escape from resettlement villages. To make it legal, they were all sentenced to five years in the Gulag "for illegally crossing the border" (explain it to the judge that the border crossed you). On the first night in June, the "singles" were picked up; on the second, and third, the families. On the second night they picked up the Wistreichs (Hanka, Staszek, Reggie, Eva, and Hugo), loaded them into a horse drawn cart, and drove them to the railroad station. I walked with the cart most of the way and gave Reggie my watch when we parted. The watch had a history. In 1938, Roman Schochet, who was a year younger than us, was threatened with an F in Latin. The teacher, professor Gajewski, told the desperate mother that she should ask me to help him. I did and he got a passing grade. The Schochets gave me a nice watch, since I would not accept money. I believe that professor Gajewski—who was a prominent member of the nationalist party, "Endecja," and a respected member of the Teachers Council—wanted to signal that he appreciated our friendship with his nephew Zdzisek Sopinski.

The next day they came for our neighbors with a truck. Even though they did not have my mother and me on the list, I asked them to take us too (I figured we could easily take all our belongings on a truck). They did

not mind to oblige. Inek Einziger, who stayed with us, decided to join us. Somehow I hoped that we may be reunited with the family.

Thousands of policemen and Internal Ministry NKVD troops were mobilized for this operation. At the railroad station we boarded freight cars (about 40 people per car). The train was guarded by soldiers.

In the corner of the car was a hole used as a toilet. We constructed a curtain from blankets for at least some privacy. There was one small window in the car.

Finally, the train started to move. The first station we stopped at was Tarnopol. I looked through the window and there was my uncle Iziu walking between the tracks. I yelled "Iziu." He ran to the train door and I saw shock in his face. I asked him to bring us some bread. Within minutes he returned with three loaves (Iziu was not subject to deportation because he was born in the area). All our relatives and friends who were not deported were very worried about us. Actually, we were the lucky ones. The decision to move us to the interior saved our lives. Most of the "lucky" ones who stayed perished when the Germans occupied that territory.

The train moved at a slow pace. We had absolutely no idea where we were being taken. Occasionally we stopped at a station and the guards would bring us some soup. Once we stopped in a field, and they let us out of the train for a few minutes. I observed a very dignified lady relieve herself under the train—obviously she was too embarrassed to do it in the car. After some 10 days we reached Kozmodemyansk, a small town on the Volga. There we were transferred to barges, which took us to a village on Vyetluga River, where we were taken to a school building. We spent a night there being eaten alive by mosquitoes. Never having seen a mosquito before, we left all the windows open.

WORKING IN THE FOREST

In the morning, trucks that used wood cubes as fuel took us to Nuzyary, a barrack settlement in the forest on a pristine lake. We shared a room with

another family for a few weeks. Later, new barracks were built, and we got our own room.

After a couple of days of rest we were divided into teams and marched into different forest sections, where we were shown how to cut trees (no power tools). Our foreman was a very decent, patient guy. We did not fell many trees on that first day. As a matter of fact, we never produced the quota that we were supposed to meet.

The water in the lake was cold and crystal clear—great for swimming, but we hardly ever swam because we had enough exercise working in the forest.

After a couple of months, I became the brigade leader of the "Youth Brigade." Actually, the brigade consisted of only three people: Inek, Wolf (a cobbler's apprentice from a small town), and me. Wolf was a nice guy but he always insisted on having the last word in a conversation ("I will tell you better," he would always say).

We worked well together and managed to fulfill 50% of the quota. For that we were praised, and I was rewarded with a trip to town, where I bought produce, which I shared with others.

Our settlement was guarded first by three, later by two policemen—actually quite decent guys. At first there was a sort of roll call in the evening to make sure that nobody escaped. Later it was discontinued. Actually, a couple of the men escaped and returned to Poland, where they were undoubtedly killed when the war started.

Every Saturday evening, there was a dance attended by young and old. The band and the singer were settlers. The prettiest girl in the village was my girlfriend (we shared the room with her family before we got our own room). In my free time I taught her whatever English I knew, and she taught me French and we mixed work with pleasure.

For a short time I worked in another village as a tractor driver's helper. We worked nights, pulling sleds loaded with lumber on ice tracks (before

pulling the loaded sleds we pulled a big water tank on sleds, which made ice tracks). We pulled loads, which would require 20–25 trucks to carry on one trip. On a clear night with stars and moon shining, the quietude of the forest was awe inspiring. I did not last long on this job (I poured oil in wrong opening). I was lucky not to be accused of sabotage.

I did end up in court later, though, but with very pleasant results. One day I received a summons, which stated that I am charged with forest violation. What it meant was that my brigade cut trees in a protected section, which was not my fault. We cut where we were told. I showed the summons to the senior policeman who cursed the SOB who put the blame on me. He assigned his subordinate to go with me and explain it to the judge. It was perhaps a fifteen mile walk. We stopped at his parents' for lunch (he was a local) and proceeded to the district seat. The judge was very annoyed with the accusation, apologized to me, and made a speech about how now we are allies against Hitler (this happened after Russo-German war broke out).

I was one of the few settlers who could read and communicate in Russian, which enabled me to befriend our foremen, who accepted my somewhat exaggerated work reports without questioning.

One of the foremen, an ethnic Mari, was interested in one aspect of life in a capitalist country. "Tell me Adam," he asked me once, "How do you know what to pay when you visit a whorehouse?" He was so used to everything having a government price. I assured him that he would be informed beforehand.

Of my memories at Nuzyary, four stand out.

Blueberries in the season: You could sit in one place and collect a bucket.

Tree Syrup: When going to work in the spring we would cut an opening in the tree, insert into it a tongue fashioned of bark and on the way back, collected a can of syrup

Felling trees in winter: The trees were so pretty all covered with snow. When a tree fell, there was a cloud of snow, which was a majestic sight.

Lunch in Winter: We had to toast our bread in the fire. It was completely frozen as it contained a lot of water (the baker was a thief who substituted water for flour).

In June 1941, the war between Germany and the Soviet Union broke out. I remember sitting in a circle of settlers and translating a newspaper article about the war. Everybody was so excited.

A couple of months later, we were told that an agreement had been signed between the Soviet government and the Polish government in London. On the basis of this agreement, all Polish citizens held in camps and settlements were to be released and permitted to travel to any chosen destination (except for a few cities). We knew where our family lived in the Ural Mountains area and decided to travel there (by we, I mean my mother, Inek, and I).

At this point, let me give due credit to Inek. He was a loyal member of our family, who always tried his best to contribute as much as he could to the common household.

TRAVELS TO THE URALS

On our trip north, we were joined by Uncle Staszek's cousin, a dermatologist from Krakow, and his family, which included his in-laws. We boarded a Volga steamer in Kozmodemyansk and traveled up the Volga to Perm (we slept on the deck), where we took a train to Nizhny, Tagil, and later to Krasnouralsk, where we found that our family had left the settlement.

We settled for the time being in Krasnouralsk. The doctor started working at a general clinic. Inek and I did not take jobs (if we did, we would face a penalty of at least six months in a prison if we decided to leave without permission). In the clinic, the discipline was not as strict. In the meantime, we kept busy collecting potatoes and other products from grateful patients.

In the spring we decided to leave for Kazakhstan, where the climate was better and the food not as scarce as in the Urals, where many factories from

the Ukraine had been evacuated.

Krasnouralsk was located on a branch line, so we had to take a local train to the main line. We tried it one night, but unfortunately on that night the baggage car was full and no baggage was accepted. We took the local train back and in the morning Kuba went to work as if nothing happened. We succeeded on our next try a few nights later.

KAZAKHSTAN

The trip to Kazakhstan took eight days. The change of scenery was stunning: from forested hills of the Urals to the plains of central Asia.

Finally, we arrived in Chimkent, where we spent the night as guests of a Russian family. There was some dancing, in which we, first reluctantly, then with enthusiasm, participated. In the morning, we took a local train to Lenger Ugol, a small coal-mining town, where some of our family friends lived. From there we moved to a collective farm about ten miles away where we worked in the fields and in transporting grain to the elevators. I mastered handling an oxen team. The members of the collective farm were Ukrainians who were encouraged by both the tsarist and Soviet governments to settle in the area inhabited by Kazakh nomads.

A couple of months after our arrival to the collective farm, we received summons to appear before the Russian medical commission for examinations for the Polish army. It was at least a fifteen mile walk. I was pronounced healthy and best suited for light artillery. From there we hopped a freight train to the encampment of the Polish army. We arrived late and our reception was quite unfriendly. We did not even get a cup of coffee. We spent the night standing in a big tent, as there was not enough room to sit down, and it was raining hard outside. In the morning, we were sent on our way. Our demands for some kind of acknowledgment that we showed up were ignored. Their attitude was understandable. At least 80% of Polish citizens in the Soviet Union were Jewish. It was unthinkable to enter Poland with a Jewish army. Anyhow, we were relieved and my mother even

more so.

Soon after that, the Wistreich family arrived and the family was reunited. At that point, cousin Kuba moved to the district seat where he took a job with the health administration. Inek went with Kuba's family. Reggie, Eva, and I spent the summer on the collective farm, helping with the harvest.

After the summer, we were faced with the choice of what to do. We wanted to continue our education, but the only schools in Chimkent were a technical college and a nursing school. We did not know that one of Moscow's medical schools was evacuated to Dzhambul some 200 miles away. If we knew, we would have tried our luck there. In Chimkent, the nursing school was certainly more appealing than the technical college. Another important consideration was that if we were arrested (anybody could be arrested whether guilty or not) and sent to Gulag, with a medical background, we would be assigned to a camp hospital, which guaranteed survival. At the nursing school, we were accepted with open arms. There were one hundred girls in the school and three boys. Most of the instructors were also female. It is not surprising that we were popular. In addition to attending classes, which were very, very easy for us, we also provided all kinds of services to the school. Probably the most memorable was when we saved the school in a "latrine crisis." The school's latrine was overflowing and the only solution was to dig a big hole next to it and connect it. It took a couple of days to dig a big hole (one of the other male students was helping us). When the hole was ready for connection we drew straws and unfortunately it became my job. I hit the wall with a spade a couple of times and then all of a sudden I heard a hiss. The boys pulled me out quickly and within a couple of minutes the hole was full. The gas pushed the contents of the latrine with a force of an explosion. If the boys did not pull me out as quickly as they did, I could have drowned in that stuff. Anyhow, the latrine was saved and we were rewarded with extra nursing uniforms, which could be exchanged for food.

ANOTHER VIGNETTE OF LIFE IN CHIMKENT

On the way to school we always passed a store, which supplied families of professional soldiers or perhaps officers only. Its shelves were not bare like in regular stores. Sometimes the manager would ask us to give a hand loading or unloading and paid us in bread.

One afternoon he asked us to hop on a truck and help an air force sergeant to get some barrels of kerosene from the warehouse. We thought nothing of it and were glad to help.

A couple of months later the same sergeant saw me on the street and asked me to follow him to the criminal investigator's office, where I had to con-

LEFT: ME, VICTOR, AND REGGIE IN CHIMKENT
RIGHT: REGGIE, ME, AND VICTOR IN CHIMKENT

firm that we helped loading these barrels.

It came out that the administrator of the local air force school—a major, noted for his drinking—sold that kerosene illegally to the store manager.

Luckily the investigator had no beef with us—we had no idea what was going on. We did not even have to testify. The store manager got five years. He was a wounded veteran, who probably got to manage the jail store. The major was sentenced to service in "punishment battalion," which meant certain death.

In the nursing school I met the great love of my youth, Nina Yashyna. She was a young graduate of Leningrad Medical School, who taught internal

diseases at our school. She was flirting with me and I found courage to ask her to a movie. It was an American movie—"Sun Valley Serenade"—which was the only foreign movie shown in the Soviet Union during the war. Actually, that movie was quite subversive. It showed happy, well dressed people having a great time at a ski resort. No exploited proletarian in sight.

This was the beginning of a great relationship. I was truly in love. The logistics were not easy because it was difficult to find privacy, but somehow we managed. Once we even made love on a table in the bazaar, which was closed for the night. She was a pretty young woman with an engaging smile and that great Russian figure. As Pushkin said, "Even when I sleep, those pretty Russian legs are in my dreams." We both realized that this relationship had no future, but it was great while it lasted. Probably she was about six years older than me, but so much more interesting than my classmates.

I remember once she came very upset. She told me that she was summoned to NKVD and had to promise that she would work for them. What happened was that she befriended a woman, whose husband was stationed in Iran. After a few months, the woman asked her to give her a certificate, stating that she was ill, hoping to get permission for him to visit her. She reported it to NKVD. Nina was summoned and a major there told her that she committed a crime, but as a Leningrader like herself, he was willing to forget it, if she would work for him.

Needless to say she was a lousy agent.

In the winter of 1942/43 I got pneumonia. There were no medicines available even in the black market, but help came from an unexpected source. One of our classmates, a beautiful Eurasian girl approached Reggie and handed him a container of sulfidine (the wonder drug before penicillin) saying "I heard Adam is sick. Hope this will help him." Her sister was Head of the District Health Administration and was in a position to get this medicine, which was available only to high dignitaries. I am mentioning this to show the generosity of Russian people to strangers. I hardly knew that girl.

In 1942, we met and befriended Victor Weinsztein (Winston in the U.S.) We have been friends ever since. This friendship was encouraged by his mother, who believed that we were the type of friends he needed. Anyhow, there was nobody else from our "milieu" in Chimkent so it was natural that we should become friends.

You will notice that Victor is frequently mentioned in my memoirs. Our friendship withstood the test of time.

Sometime later we had an interesting experience with the NKVD (predecessor of KGB). There was a young NKVD lieutenant, who loved to strut in the streets in his dreaded uniform. Whenever he passed us, he smiled and we smiled back. He misunderstood our politeness—he thought that we would like to work for him.

One day, we got a summons to appear at the police headquarters at 9pm (security services always worked at night).

Our friendly lieutenant was there, and he started by telling us that he admired our friendship and blah, blah, blah. Then he told us that he knew that we were friends of the Wajnsztein family and asked what we usually talk about when we visit them. We told him that the last time we talked about differences between the Polish and Lithuanian languages. He probed and probed. Finally, I told him, "Lieutenant, you really do not think that we would be informing on our friends?" He responded that we have to work together because we are allies in the war against Hitler, etc. What saved us was that he was not prepared. Any NKVD officer worth his salt would have had something to blackmail us with. He was a son of a high NKVD officer, who got him a plushy job far away from the front. He did not have to be smart, and he was not. Actually, he was a nice guy with a lot of time on his hands. We kept on smiling at each other when we passed in the street. By the way, the NKVD was interested in Victor's father, Dr. Weinsztein, because in Vilno he was active in Zionist politics.

JAIL

Before the start of my romance with Nina, I spent six weeks in jail. It was certainly an experience. The reason I landed in jail was that I refused to accept a Soviet passport. Actually, it was all a stupid mistake because the Soviet passports issued to Polish citizens had a special annotation that made them different. What happened was that the Soviet government broke relations with the Polish government in London, and it was decided that Polish citizens in the Soviet Union had to get identity documents.

Reggie was lucky. When the policeman came to our dormitory, he thought he had only me on the list. By the time he realized that Reggie was also on the list, he was gone. Anyhow, after spending a few days in the police precinct jail (with a wooden floor and other Polish refugees for company), I was transferred to the regular jail. When I entered the cell there were about 40 people lying on a concrete floor. The only place available was next to the "parasha," a huge barrel used as a toilet. Twice a day, two prisoners took the barrel to the yard where they emptied it. In a few days I moved away from the parasha. About a week later I was told that in a few days, the court would examine my case. The judge and two jurors came to the prison, where the hearing was held. I was told that I was charged with vagrancy because I have no documents and refused to accept the Soviet passport. My protestations that I was a student, not a vagrant, were ignored.

Then there was the turn for my appointed lawyer. He asked the court for compassion because I was young and I was brought up in a capitalist society and did not realize what an honor it is to have a Soviet passport. After that I was let out for a few minutes. Then I was brought back and the judge read my sentence. I was sentenced to two years of prison and three years of deprivation of civil rights (what civil rights?). I was handed this sentence, which was in rather poor Russian. One day after the sentencing, I was transferred to a cell for convicted prisoners. Most of the prisoners were robbers and thieves, but I was lucky. A Polish refugee, whose sister I knew, was the "advisor" and deputy of hunchback Ivan, the cell boss. He quickly took me under his wing and instructed me that if I get a parcel from home,

I should immediately give half of its contents to Ivan and keep the rest. Otherwise, the criminals would take everything.

There was no radio, books, or newspapers in that cell, so someone who could tell an interesting story got immediately popular. I told them stories from Greek mythology, Anderson's fables, etc.

A few days later, when I was already expecting to be shipped to the Gulag, I was called out and led to a room where Victor's mother was standing with my lawyer. She told me that I should accept the passport because it does not mean anything and everybody has taken it. The lawyer gave me a sheet of paper to sign, and I was returned to my cell. For two days I worried that my papers may get lost and I would be shipped out but two days after Victor's mother's visit I was released.

Looking at it in retrospect, my stint in jail was a very interesting experience. It would not have been if I landed in a Gulag.

ME, REGGIE, AND VICTOR
AT STUART'S WEDDING

I was embarrassed to go back to school. After all, everybody knew why I missed six weeks of classes. However, all my classmates and teachers went out of their way to be nice to me. Our old librarian said to me, "Nothing to be embarrassed about. You did not kill anybody, you did not steal anything." She told me a Russian verse, which in rough translation means "Who did not sit in jail, will, and who sat there will not forget." It rhymes in Russian.

We graduated with honors and the question arose of what to do next. Most of our classmates were drafted to the Army Medical Corps. The rest were assigned to some distant districts, where doctors were scarce and could not be spared for administrative and diagnostic work. We had the right to prescribe medicine and perform minor emergency operations.

VICTOR'S MOTHER REBECCA

LIFE IN MOSCOW AND MIGRATION TOWARD THE UNITED STATES

Again, Victor and his mother came to the rescue. Victor's mother Rebecca was a highly educated woman, whose native tongue was Russian, because Vilno was a Russian province before World War I. She taught English at a local college. One of her students was Nora Stetskova, a daughter of colonel Stetskov, chief of NKVD for south Kazakhstan. Nora adored Victor's mother and got her mother to invite her for tea. Victor's mother was a charming woman and had no difficulty befriending Mrs. Stetskova. When Victor, Reggie and I decided that it would be great to study in Moscow, his mother mentioned it to Mrs. Stetskova, who asked her husband to arrange it. He was the most feared man in a large district, who had absolute power over everybody except for his wife and only daughter.

He resisted but finally yielded. Mrs. Stetskova told Victor's mother that we should get a letter from the head of our school stating that we are in the top 5% of the graduating class and should be given an opportunity to continue our studies in Moscow. With this letter we were to go to the District Police Office, where travel permits would be issued.

Everything went like clockwork—with no bureaucratic delays or requests for additional approvals or documents.

It was a real feat. I do not think that there was ever anybody (certainly not

ME, VICTOR, AND REGGIE BEFORE THE TRIP TO MOSCOW

a foreigner) who received a travel permit to Moscow, courtesy of an NKVD top man.

Moscow was like another planet; life there was infinitely better than in the provinces—only the privileged lived there.

After receiving the permits, we purchased about 120 lbs. of apples and some extra travel ration cards. Such cards wore worthless in Chimkent, but in Moscow the traveler could get anything the card entitled him to, including meat and cheese.

We managed to board the train to Moscow, but even with travel permits, tickets were not available. We got onto the platform between the cars and tried to negotiate with the conductor to let us in the car, but he was holding out for a large bribe.

In the meantime we had to fight off juvenile thieves, who tried to steal our apples. About 4 hours after departure we arrived in Arys—a key station in Central Asia—Moscow line. Victor remembered that he met the military commander of that station, when his mother shared a hospital room with his wife. It was after midnight, but the commander was working. Victor ran

to his office and told him about our predicament (the commander remembered him). He ordered his secretary to arrange for three tickets. Victor grabbed them and jumped back on the train. This all took just a few minutes. Now the conductor had to let us in without a bribe.

The trip took about a week. On the way, in Aralsk, located on the partially dried Aralsk Sea, we bought a bucket of salt, which we later sold at sizable profit in Ryazan, near Moscow.

When we lived in a boys' dormitory in Chimkent as its sole inhabitants we befriended our neighbor Mr. Malinowski—a Polish veteran of the Russian revolution of 1905.

Mr. and Mrs. Malinowski were evacuated from Moscow, when the Germans were approaching, but were able to return three years later. They lived in the Old Bolsheviks Compound in Sokolniki near Moscow. They told us to visit them if we ever came to Moscow. When we arrived, they were still not able to take possession of their room and slept on the table in the communal kitchen. They let the three of us sleep under the table.

In the morning Mrs. Malinowska made several trips to town with our apples. It took several days to sell them all, but we realized a sizable profit, which we shared with the Malinowskis. A couple of days later, Reggie moved in with his girlfriend, whom he met in the Urals. Her mother's family had roots both in Warsaw and in Moscow.

Her mother's brother—a black sheep in the family—was a communist who spent some years in jail in Poland (the Communist Party was illegal in Poland). When war broke out, he moved to Moscow, and when parts of Poland were liberated, he became a member of the puppet government, organized by Soviet authorities. His wife, Maria Wierna (also a Polish communist) became a representative of the Polish People's Government in Moscow.

One of the Moscow relatives of Marysia (Reggie's girlfriend) had a dacha near Moscow and that's where Victor and I moved when we left the Malinowskis.

Victor did not plan to be in Moscow long. Vilno was liberated and his family planned to return there as soon as possible.

In the meantime, Reggie and I visited all three medical schools in Moscow and found out that it was practically impossible to gain admission. The war was over; many veterans were coming home and they had priority. During the war, medical schools were not so popular because unlike the engineering students, medical students were not entitled to deferment.

Reggie and Victor were ready to try an engineering school (in order to stay in Moscow you had to be a bona fide student) but I was absolutely opposed.

The situation energized me and I started looking hard for some suitable school. The first school I decided to try was the School of Banking and Credit of the Central Bank of the USSR. I went there and had a nice conversation with the dean, whom I impressed with my knowledge of Latin (one of my favorite subjects in high school). He was an old gentlemen, educated probably before the Revolution. We hit it off and finally he said that he will accept me. I told him that I had a cousin of exactly the same qualifications, whom I could not leave. He agreed to accept us both.

The administrator of the school gave us a letter stating that we have been accepted and requesting for us the permission to live in Moscow. The police commander refused, saying that we can be registered only in dormitory space.

We went back to the school administrator. He asked us where we were living (we lived at Marysia's uncle's dacha), scratched his head, and gave us another letter to the police stating that the school has made arrangements with owners of dachas to house students and he requests that such dachas be considered dormitory space.

This guy really went on a limb for us and he did not know us from Adam. Russian people can be very generous to strangers, if they take a liking to them.

We took the letter to the police and amazingly it worked. The commander told his secretary to stamp our passports. She winked at us and stamped our passports. When we left that office we realized that she used a five year stamp instead of one year. This meant that we could live legally in Moscow for five years in instead of having to renew our "propiska" every year. This was a tremendous favor, but a year later we were on the way back to Poland.

Shortly after becoming a student I moved in with a family related to our friends in Lenger Ugol. Victor left for Vilno around that time. The family consisted of a widowed mother and a daughter who was a medical student.

The daughter developed a crush on me, but I tried to discourage her—good old rule: "Never get involved with somebody where you live, unless you have serious intentions." One evening though I found her "au naturel" in my bed. It took a lot of will power on my part to persuade her to go to her own bed (she had a beautiful body). When we were leaving, she came to the station and was very sad. She could have had a nervous breakdown, if I did not behave the way I did, as she was quite fragile emotionally.

Our classmates in school were nice and friendly. They had good educational backgrounds and the courses were not easy. It was actually a very good school. It had an international banking department, where only very trusted people were accepted (usually sons and daughters of communist dignitaries).

In the spring of 1946, I felt lonely for Nina. I arranged for a medical certificate issued by Kuba that my mother is sick. With this certificate, dressed in the best clothing of the three of us, I went to the public affairs office of the Central Administration of Police of the USSR (residents of Moscow had the right to complain, petition, etc. with an officer of that office). I was received by a police major. He listened politely, but I had a feeling that he would refuse. Before he had a chance to do that, I told him that whether he gives me the permit or not I will go anyway. I told him that I realized I may be arrested and expelled from school, but I would take that chance. He smiled and said, "I see you are a determined young man, so I better give

you the permit." The next day, I went to the railroad station. All the tickets for my train were sold. I noticed a young soldier girl who was ready for boarding. I took off my overcoat and handed it to her, with my bag, and told her I would join her in the car. A few minutes later, when the train was ready to leave, I went past a conductor, who I assumed that I was one of the passengers (or perhaps expected a bribe later).

In Ryazan, I went out and bought him a bottle of whiskey. My travel was uneventful. The NKVD inspection teams treated holders of a permit issued by Central Administration of Police with due respect.

That was my last meeting with Nina. She told me that she was going to marry a classmate from medical school, who was a colonel in the medical corps and a party member (that solved her problem with NKVD). This was a good and practical solution. We parted as friends, and I will always remember her. She probably passed away because she would be 98 years old now, but I will remember her as a beautiful young woman. The rest of the trip was uneventful. I was able to procure some travel ration cards, which were worth nothing in Chimkent, but were very valuable in Moscow.

Occasionally we worked part time for the Polish Legation listening to broadcasts from liberated areas of Poland. It was great to be connected to the Legation because we could get tickets to plays, operas, ballets, and first run movies.

Actually, it was a great way to meet a pretty girl. The lines for new films were always horribly long. I would inspect the line, find a pretty girl, and would say, "I have two tickets. I'd be delighted to share them with you." It always worked. I struck a friendship with a girl, who was an apprentice dancer with Moiseyev ballet. She was only 19, so she may still be living.

RETURN TO POLAND

A few months into our second semester we were given a choice—to return to Poland or to continue in Moscow. It was a no-brainer to choose the first, even though we would have good career opportunities as graduates of a

prestigious school. You were never safe there, no matter what position you held.

We traveled from Poland to the Soviet Union in a freight car with a hole for a toilet. When we traveled back to Poland, we occupied a private compartment in a luxurious sleeping car (with a private bathroom). We had such accommodation because we were traveling with Reggie's girlfriend's family, who received diplomatic courtesy through Mrs. Wierna. Unfortunately, we had to change trains at the Polish border because of the difference in track width. When we got to Warsaw the train stopped a mile before the station, which was destroyed. Reggie and Marysia's stepfather went to look for a telephone to call her uncle. I was left with the two women.

On the track next to ours stood a Russian military train with soldiers returning from Germany. All of a sudden a soldier ran out of one of the cars, grabbed one of our suitcases and ran back to his car. The Polish people who were standing nearby shook their heads and told me to forget it because I could be killed if I tried to intervene.

I ignored them, found the command car and told the commanding officer in slightly accented good Russian that I am accompanying the family of the Polish Deputy Minister of Security (which was true) and that I demand immediate return of the stolen suitcase. He gave me two MPs, I pointed at the car, and in a minute they found the suitcase. To impress me, they arrested the guilty soldier.

Soon Reggie and the stepfather arrived in a large car, which took us to a villa surrounded by a high fence. I slept there only one night and the next day, I took the train to Łodz, where my father's pharmacy was located.

Actually, Marysia's uncle was not comfortable as Deputy Minister of Security and managed to get appointed as Poland's ambassador to China. He became a skillful and respected diplomat and kept his job after Poland became independent.

As I entered the pharmacy, I saw uncle Iziu. He kissed me and said, "This place is yours. I will help you run it for a while."

I found a place to stay with our (and later Uncle Michał's) cook who married a police lieutenant after the war. Often I had meals there. She was a much better cook than she was in Jasło, where my mother held her back.

When I needed privacy, the pharmacy had a room for the night duty pharmacist, which was used twice a month. On other nights, it was my "bachelor's pied a terre."

While Łodz was my primary residence, I spent a lot of time with our family in Krakow (our family returned to Poland from Kazakhstan a couple of months after us). Train travel was not quite safe yet. From time to time we heard about murders of Jews on trains. A group of several bandits would stop the train and check the cars for anybody looking or sounding Jewish. Anybody who did would be taken off the train and shot. Luckily these occurrences became quite rare as the general security in the country improved.

The trains were pitch dark at night and a lot was going on in the darkness—some of it enjoyable.

We concluded that there is no future for us in communist Poland and decided to emigrate. The pharmacy was very profitable but I got only $2000, when I sold it to a pharmacist who was a veteran of the People's Army, not too worried about the possibility of nationalization. We left Poland in September 1947 after a year's stay.

PARIS

Our relatives in New York got us "Paraguayan permits" which stated that the holders of such document will receive immigration visas upon appearance in the Paraguayan consulate in Paris. Such papers could be bought in New York for about $100. With these papers, we applied for and received French transit visas. The French consul in Łodz, where I got visas for my mother and myself, was an honest man. He charged only the regular small fee. The consul in Krakow had a bag lady who had to be paid $50 for each visa. Exit visas from Poland were no problem. The Polish government,

which included many Jews in key positions, encouraged Jewish emigration hoping that this will reduce anti-Semitism. Ethnic Poles were not permitted to emigrate.

Finally, in the fall of 1947, we boarded the train to Paris with hopes and anxiety—to start a new chapter of our lives.

In Paris we settled in a small cheap hotel near the railroad station. Every day we got a lousy tasting meal in the refugee kitchen. Occasionally my mother would cook a "one pot meal" on a little camp stove. It was amazing that she mastered the art of cooking a decent meal under difficult conditions faster than other females in the family.

With all that, we had a great time in Paris. It is such a beautiful and exciting city. The public transportation was excellent and cheap, and the entertainment was not costly either. We started taking French lessons at "Alliance

ME, GERT, BERNARD, AND HIS WIFE JUDY

Francaise." One of our classmates was Bernard Kaluszyner, whose family (or rather part of his family) emigrated to France well before the war and was quite well off. As sole survivor of the Polish branch of the family, he came to Paris right after the war. The family helped him to establish himself first in clothing and later in the pearl importing business.

He was a very likable guy and we quickly became good friends. He introduced us to French liqueurs, of which he kept a large selection in his apartment. We went to movies and museums together. We stayed in touch, even after we emigrated to the U.S. He died in a tragic accident the day before his daughter's wedding. He was crushed by a moving tractor while cutting grass at his "chateau" (actually it was just a very large villa) near Paris.

BERNARD'S "CHATEAU" NEAR PARIS

USA

In early July 1948, we got a letter from Victor, who at that time was a student at Columbia University. He had come to the U.S. early because he was born in Berlin, where his mother was visiting her sisters. He said, "if you guys want to come to the U.S. now, send me your school papers and leave the rest to me. You will be here for the next semester."

He kept his word. Not only did we get accepted, but we were given 45 credits. 12 credits for Polish, 12 for Russian, 12 for Ukrainian (I only can curse in Ukrainian), and 9 for our studies at the school of banking. With admission papers for Columbia, we went to the American consulate and received visas within a few days. The transportation to the U.S. was arranged by Marian Ratner, a friend who was working for some Jewish organization. He managed to get us on a chartered plane for Jewish intellectuals, who were to attend a conference in New York.

It was a propeller plane. The trip took some 23 hours.

When we got to New York, I was met by a nasty immigration inspector who told me that he won't let me in because I do not have a return visa and sent me to Ellis Island. Reggie's inspector let him in without any fuss.

Ellis Island was another interesting experience. I slept in a large dormitory, which was practically empty (there were no masses of immigrants to be processed anymore). A few years ago I received a call from a member of

the staff of the Ellis Island Museum, who wanted to interview me. I told her that I only spent one night there and had nothing to tell her, but she insisted. She came to see me and taped my life story. I guess there are very few people alive who went through Ellis Island.

Anyhow, in the morning uncle Elek came, posted a bond for me, and I was let go. This was just in time because that evening we were to attend the big wedding of Reggie's first cousin Elaine. Without me Reggie could not have gone because I had all the pants in my suitcase while he had all the jackets.

It was a true New Jersey Jewish wedding with schmaltzy music and with a variety and selection of food like we had never seen.

The next day we moved to the International House. It was a great place, where we met many interesting young people, both foreign and American. Nobody was supposed to live there longer than one year but we managed to spend two and a half years there.

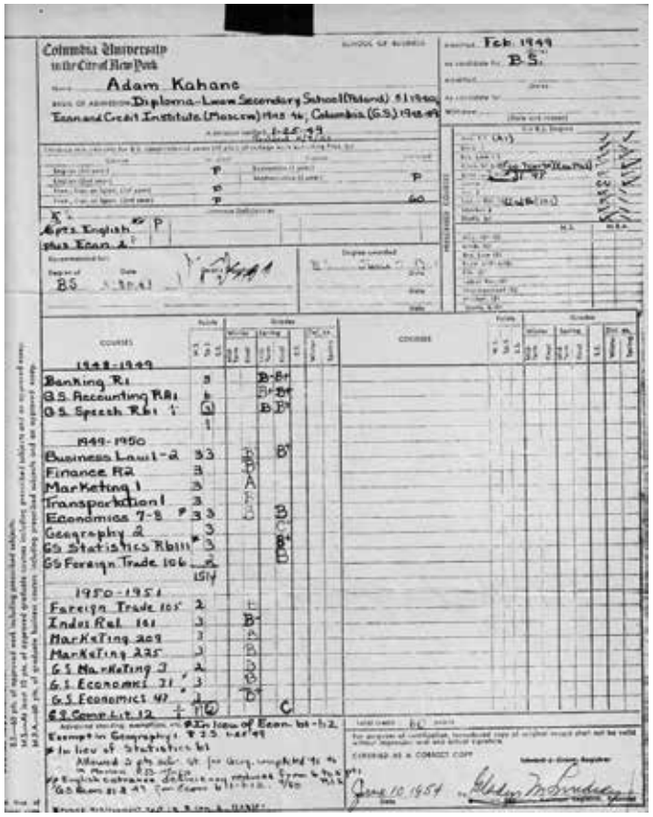
We worked in the cafeteria two and a half hours a day for all our meals, and a few hours a week in the checkroom for our room.

On Saturday evening we often had entertainment, sometimes featuring big names like Burl Ives or Leontine Price (who actually lived in the International House).

The academic year passed quickly. For the summer we decided to try our luck in the Catskills. We found busboy jobs in the New Congress hotel on Sackett Lake.

The work was hard but the tips were good and we were lucky to keep our jobs the entire season. The clientele of the hotel consisted mainly of Bronx and Brooklyn families fleeing their hot apartments (this was before air conditioning). The breadwinner of the family would often come only for the weekend. We were encouraged to dance with the girls to make their stay more fun. We did not shirk that duty.

The main attraction of the hotel was the excellent food prepared under the supervision of Mrs. Broder, a Hungarian born head cook who became our


Columbia University in the City of New York
Adam Kahane
Feb. 1949
B.S.
1948-1949
Banking R1
B.S. Accounting R1
B.S. Speech R1
1949-1950
Business Law 1-2
Finance R2
Marketing 1
Transportation 1
Economics 7-8
Geography 2
GS Statistics R111
GS Foreign Trade 106
1950-1951
Foreign Trade 105
Indus Rel 101
Marketing 209
Marketing 225
GS Marketing 3
GS Economics 31
GS Economics 47
GS Comm Lit 12
June 10, 1954

TRANSCRIPT OF COURSES AT COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY

friend and protector.

While working in the New Congress I received a letter from the dean of Columbia's School of Business notifying me that I was accepted to the School of Business and would not have to pay tuition. At that time, Columbia School of Business was an undergraduate school. Actually, after I graduated it became a graduate school. I never applied to the School of Business but probably mentioned that this was my field of interest. I never told anybody in our American family about this letter because I did not want to embarrass Reggie.

The American family were uncle Staszek's two brothers and their families. They were very nice to us and treated me the same as Reggie. Almost every Friday, we would be invited to an excellent dinner.

ADAM IN 1955. 170LB, 5'10.5"

As I said, at the International House we had many interesting friends, some of whom became prominent in their countries. I remember Bibi Albonetti, a scion of an old Roman family, who used say, "Coito ergo sum" instead of "Cogito ergo sum" (I screw therefore I am instead of I think therefore I am). He later became a member of the Italian Atomic Commission.

Another of our friends Virgilio Hilario from Manila had a white convertible Oldsmobile but liked to keep the top down because he worried that a tan would make him look like a lower class person. Eventually he married Miss Universe.

Some of our American friends made careers in diplomatic services.

Another school year passed and we got back to the Catskills—this time as waiters. It was a very profitable summer.

As I mentioned, the head cook—a childless Hungarian immigrant—practically adopted us because we reminded her of young Hungarians she knew

in her youth. It was almost embarrassing the way we were favored. Our orders were filled without any waiting and we could provide the best and fastest service to our customers, which did not hurt the tips. Once a new waiter, who did not know the rules, protested. Mrs. Broder, who had a terrible temper, chased him out of the kitchen. Because the reputation and profitability of the hotel was built on her great cooking, even the owner was afraid to offend her.

We ended that season with $2000 in tips. Considering that at the time a thick pastrami sandwich was 25 cents (bologna and liverwurst were only 15) this was a nice chunk of money. Some years later, when I was married and settled in Washington, Gert (my wife) and I visited Mrs. Broder in her Bronx apartment, where she retired, and brought her flowers. She was very moved.

By the end of the fall semester I completed my degree requirements (my diploma was issued in June 1951) and started looking for a job. Reggie had still one semester to go.

A couple of weeks later I was recruited to the CIA by Victor, who was working there. During the seven years of my employment there I did very little productive work. Frankly, I wasted taxpayers' money, but I became Americanized and my English improved. Also, I managed to get a Master's degree.

One morning, two years into my employment at the CIA, I got a call from an immigration lawyer, who told me that he saw in a congressional record that Senator Langner of North Dakota (also known as "Wild Bill Langner") submitted a private bill on my behalf, which made me eligible for citizenship. The lawyer thought that perhaps I have access to senator Langner which I could share with him. I told him that this was news to me.

I went to the Library of Congress and I found it. Some 20 years later, I looked for that item again and could not find it. Most likely my name was deleted for security reasons.

Anyhow, I can tell my grandchildren that their grandfather had his

LEFT: GERT BEFORE THE WEDDING. RIGHT: OUR WEDDING PICTURE

immigration status changed by an act of congress—an act which only applied to him. Obviously this was arranged for by my employer, but nobody told me about it.

In early 1952 I married Gertrude Lass, whose father came from Poland before World War 1 to be followed by his wife right after the war. Gert was the only member of the family born in the U.S. (Sioux City, Iowa).

As you see from our wedding pictures, she was a pretty blonde with a good figure. I was impressed by her efficiency and "can do" attitude. We had a good marriage for over 50 years. She was a good marriage partner and made a great contribution to our business.

After seven years at the CIA, I was offered a job in Paris. It was a somewhat boring, but sensitive job. I was very excited. The idea of living in Paris, not as a penniless refugee, but a middle class American had a strong appeal for me. Our family still lived in Paris and I had friends there. To make a long story short, I passed all kinds of tests but my polygraph test was inconclusive. There was a simple reason for it. I concealed the fact that I had an uncle living in Communist Poland because I felt this could disqualify me

GERT'S PARENTS

for sensitive positions because I could be exposed to blackmail.

In retrospect that was probably one of the best things that happened to me. I was not cut out to be a CIA man due to my temperament and personality.

Instead, within a year, I was on my way to become a successful businessman doing something I loved.

But let's go back to the time when the Paris job offer was withdrawn. I decided I should start looking for something else. Luckily, just about that time my old friend Victor opened an office of his company in D.C.

The company's name was Scripta Technica and it was a division or subsidiary of Royer and Rogers, a New York company which for some reason received a $300,000 contract from the Air Force to translate a book by a Swedish explorer who traveled in Central Asia in the 19th century. Victor offered me a job as a project manager. I accepted his offer with a proviso that in winter I will work part-time because I planned to start a ski business. At Scripta I met Belle, Victor's future wife, who became my valued friend. She is a charming and interesting person.

We assembled a crew of excellent translators, typists, and proofreaders (some worked part-time) and we started the ball rolling. Being an expert in wasting time and money I had no problem adjusting to this job.

In March 1959, after starting at Scripta, we incorporated as Ski Tours Inc, (doing business as Ski Center) and applied for an ICC license (in those days a license was necessary to transport passengers between states). It was not easy to get such a license because any objection could delay it for a long time. We were represented by a young and inexperienced lawyer. I was approached by a lawyer of one of the local bus companies, who told me that unless I agreed to use the buses of his company, he would file an objection. My young lawyer was at a loss about what to do. He even had a nosebleed, possibly because of nervousness. I offered the other lawyer to use his company buses if their rates and service are as good as other bus companies. He agreed and no objection was filed .

Before the start of the season I visited that bus company and found out that their prices were higher than of their competitors and the buses were not as modern. We signed a contract with another bus company, which provided good service at relatively low prices. Shortly after, I received a letter from the other company's lawyer accusing me of breach of contract. I ignored him and never heard from him again.

That first season we employed three people: The Leonard brothers from Vermont, who were Georgetown students and a handyman, who was a talented carpenter when he was sober, which was not very often.

Before the season I visited several local areas and was able to make a deal with Herman Dupre at Seven Springs. We shook hands and never had any-

Gert's high school class photo

at a trade show

contract. He even permitted us to teach our beginners.

The first season our weekend package sold for $39.50. It included bus transportation, two nights in a motel in Somerset, two days of skiing, instruction for beginners, two breakfasts, and a steak dinner. Eventually we raised the price to $42.50 and finally to $49.50. We hardly made any money on the trips, but developed a loyal clientele. We also ran trips for the Washington Ski Club to New England and Canada.

After several years we discontinued our trips as the ski business grew nicely

HUGO, REGGIE, MARGO, JURGEN, AND ME IN THE POCONOS

and the bus operation was full of headaches. When the weekend weather was bad, some people wanted to cancel, others wanted to go anyhow. It was hard to please everybody.

The stroke of luck was that just about the time we started, snowmaking was invented, which made local skiing much more reliable.

In our first year our gross sales were only about $17,000, but I realized our potential. It doubled the second year, and kept on growing. It took time to reach the first $1,000,000.

I enjoyed being in the ski business tremendously. It certainly helped that my wife was such a good and reliable partner. Every night, when I was walking home from the bus stop I sang silly songs to myself. I felt like a right man in the right place. Perhaps I felt that way because none of my ancestors worked for somebody else. The exception was my mother's brother Mundek, an engineer who worked for the Dutch government building railroads in what at the time were the Dutch Indies (now Indonesia). My mother's sisters and brothers were professionals, but the ancestors further up the line were merchants.

A couple of years after we started, we were able to get a Head ski franchise, which was like a license to make money. People would just come and ask for this or that Head model and the sale was made.

About 3 years after we started, our only competitor Charlie Brun retired and for a few years we had a monopoly. I had to buy Charlie's inventory, which included a lot of Swiss Henke boots, which fit few people and took us a few years to sell. Henkes were the first buckle boots. Their slogan was: "You are racing, while others are lacing."

After one year in a basement on I street, we moved to 912 11th street, where we stayed for over 10 years. During the second year of operation, we

OLD STORE PHOTO

GERT AND ME AT THE NEW STORE, 1982

hired Bob McGowan, who was a good mechanic and a pleasant guy to be with. He was only 45, but already retired from submarine service. He was a superb skier, and I shared him sometimes with Hans Geyer, director of the Roundtop ski school. The first year he was kind of shy but later he became a true ladies man. Our success in business has been based on the fact that we were able to attract and keep some great employees.

Boyd McHugh and Brian Eardley have been with us for over 35 years; Brian Beaumont, Kirk Evans, and Jimmy Martin, have been with with us over 25 years; and even newcomers like Kristin O'Brien and Steve West have been with us over 20 years.

Another of our key employees was Doug Colley who was our service manager for about fifteen years. There was nothing he could not do with his hands. He built our Spring Valley store. Our first store manager Scott Henderson died young, and so did Jerry Juntilla and Billy Amblem. Scott died of melanoma, Billy of some blood infection, and Jerry, who was a clean cut and believer in healthy living, died of a drug overdose. Scott was a charming guy—very popular with both customers and employees.

We were very lucky that Stuart decided to join the business some 35 years ago. He is a bright, superb administrator, and a better businessman than I ever was. He expanded the business very substantially and brought us into the computer age. I am very proud of him.

Toward the end of our first season, as a project manager for Scripta, I had to take a small crew of translators and typists to St. Louis, where we had to do final corrections on the translation project.

Gert was alone in the store for about two weeks. While I was gone, she had her first encounter with a shoplifter. A French woman who was looking at the clothing, carried a large bag. When she was about to leave her bag appeared bigger. Gert asked her to open it and there was our parka. When asked how the parka got there, the woman answered, "I do not know"—the only good answer under the circumstances.

Later, when we attended a seminar on shoplifting, we were told to be very

careful about asking about seemingly concealed objects. The instructor told us a story about a couple, who would act very suspiciously and make it look like the man is carrying something under a loose overcoat. When asked by the store detective to show what he had in there, the man showed that he had nothing, and then asked to see the manager, whom he told how he was humiliated in front of many people and that he was going to sue the store. To avoid bad publicity the store would settle for cash. This couple traveled from city to city, and it was a lucrative business while it lasted.

The most difficult shoplifters to handle were those who came in groups. In such situations, the cashier would call the workshop and ask for the store manager's skis. Immediately several big guys from the workshop would come up and start showering the potential shoplifters with respectful attention. They would ask them about their favorite ski area, how long they have been skiing, etc, and generally tried to be as helpful as possible. It always worked.

A few years ago at Christmas, a man brought back an expensive parka with all our markings, and said that he got it as a gift and wanted a refund. A quick computer check showed that this parka was never sold—obviously it was shoplifted. The guy did not argue and left quickly without the parka or a refund.

Over the years we had many interesting customers and reps. One of our first reps, Red Weiss, represented several clothing firms. I met him at the first buying show and since I lacked experience, I asked him to write an order of men's ski pants with the proper size distribution. He marked the wrong boxes on the order form and when we received the pants there was nothing smaller than size 42. Most of the pants were size 44, 46, and 48. It was strange that somebody at the factory did not notice. Where did they think we would find such obese skiers? Red employed an Austrian nobleman whose name was von Hamberger. He had impeccable manners and would always invite us for lunch or dinner.

Then there was Lou, the Koflach boots salesman. Somebody once asked me why we have so many Koflach boots. "Are they great?" "No," I said. "They

MICHAEL (MY GRANDSON) AND ME

have a super salesman." Lou would make me feel guilty or silly if I did not give him a substantial order. Other ski shop owners told me the same thing. He was a charming guy—eventually he retired to Florida, where he bought a pub. I am sure his customers drank a lot and loved him.

After I quit my "safety job" at Scripta, I started spending more time at the store, often working 70 hours a week. Actually, I enjoyed working long hours. For the first time in my life I was truly productive and building a solid, profitable business.

I was never a great salesman. My sales record was good because customers trusted me. Perhaps my foreign accent had something to do with it.

Being somewhat shy when we started, I dreaded public speaking, yet I knew that I had to do it when an opportunity arose.

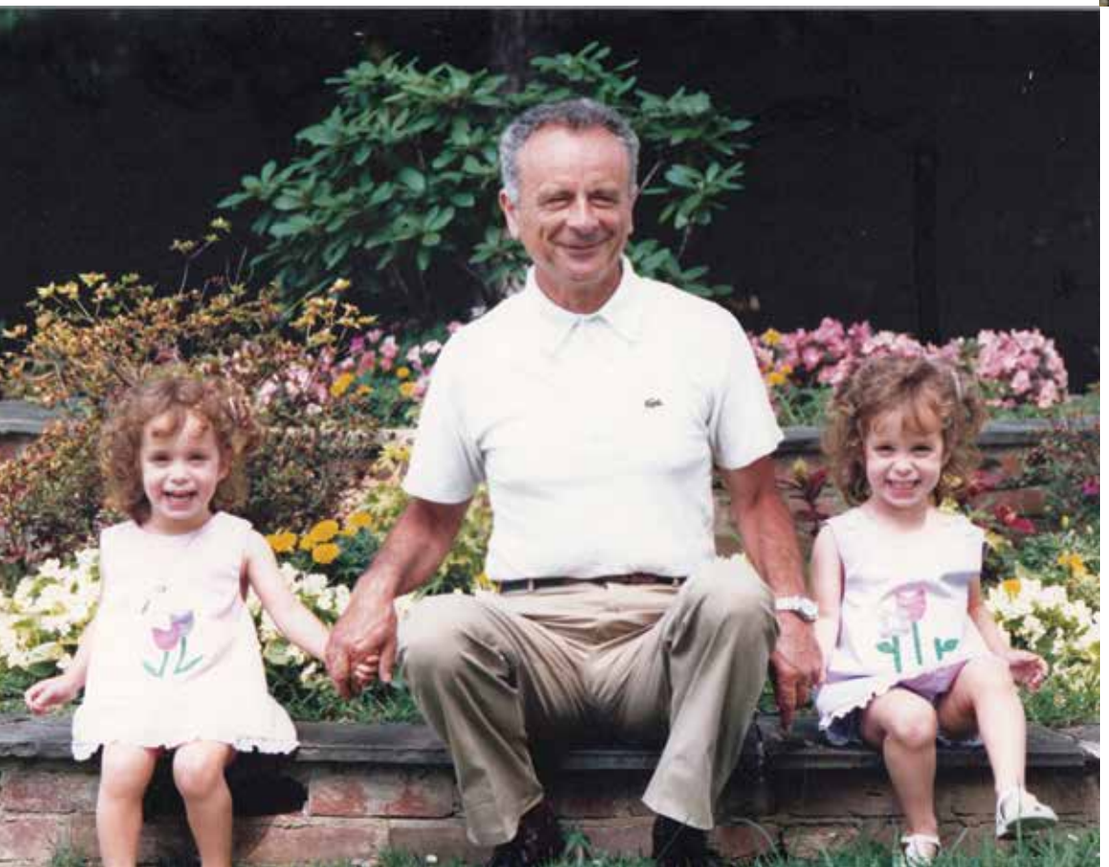
My first public speaking event was the Washington Ski Club beginners

meeting. There were more than 100 people in the audience, all potential customers. I started rather tentatively but then I noticed that a woman in the second row was falling asleep. That put me at ease right away. I said to myself that most of them are here for social reasons. They do not give a hoot what I am saying. It ended up as a good presentation.

Our most prominent customer was President Gerald Ford, who started dealing with us when he was Minority Leader of the House of Representatives. He would stop by almost every week, always jovial and smiling. Everybody loved him.

Another of our prominent customers, Vice President Dan Quayle, once decided to buy his wife an anniversary present. When he and his entourage arrived at our parking lot, they realized that she was in the store. They discreetly retreated and came back later.

ME, AGE 65, WITH BECKY AND SUSIE (GRANDDAUGTERS), 1987



ME, AGE 90, WITH BECKY AND SUSIE (GRANDDAUGTERS), 2012

There were many diplomats among our customers. One Saturday before Christmas, there were three ambassadors in the store, Swiss, German, and Austrian (that was before globalization).

I made a terrible faux pas with the wife of a British Ambassador.

She bought a set of skis and bindings and started filling out the mounting form. One of the questions dealt with age. I wanted to be nice, so I said, "You do not have to state your exact age. Just say over 40." She looked at me and said with a smile, "I am not forty yet. I only look that way."

I was so embarrassed. She certainly looked older to me. Perhaps she did not sleep well the night before.

When the safety situation downtown deteriorated, we bought a fierce looking, one year old German shepherd, named Dylan, who protected the store until we moved to Spring Valley. All day he sat in the display window and discouraged potential robbers by his sheer presence. He barked at people

STUART, ME, GERT, AND AUDREY AT OUR 25TH WEDDING ANNIVERSARY

in uniforms and at people who were afraid of him, which was sometimes quite embarrassing. One day a drunken bum came to the store and started bothering customers. I tried to convince Dylan to do something, but he was not interested. The bum was so drunk, that he was not afraid of the fierce beast. We had to throw him out ourselves.

Over 50 years I have seen many changes in our industry. Skis changed from wood to metal, then to fiberglass, and the shape changed from relatively straight, to parabolic. Boots evolved from leather with laces to highly technical plastic masterpieces. Bindings evolved from primitive cable to sophisticated modern bindings. Skiing became easier and safer. In clothing, plain, functional parkas gave way to fashionable parkas made of modern fabrics. The earliest development in ski clothing was the replacement of baggy pants by stretch pants. Ladies looked sexy and glamorous in these tight fitting pants—the fact which was not lost on men, and as a consequence

MY DAUGHTER AUDREY IN HIGH SCHOOL

STUART, ME, LINDA, AND GERT

there was a spurt of growth in the industry.

We worked hard in the winter, but our summers were free and we traveled extensively in Europe (particularly when my mother was still living) and in the U.S. Also, every spring, after the buying show, we took a ski vacation out West. Attending the shows, which for many years were held in Las Vegas, was a lot of fun. It was interesting to see the new merchandise and talk to old friends.

Las Vegas in March is such an exciting place. The weather was always beautiful—not a cloud in the sky. Deep green grass was everywhere. We did not gamble, but it was fun just watching those who did. Once walking to the Convention Center I found a $100 bill on the pavement. We looked some more and Doug Colley found another. That evening I invited them all to a dinner and show, which cost me considerably more.

WITH MY FAMILY AT MY 90TH BIRTHDAY

NEW FRIENDS IN MY LATER LIFE

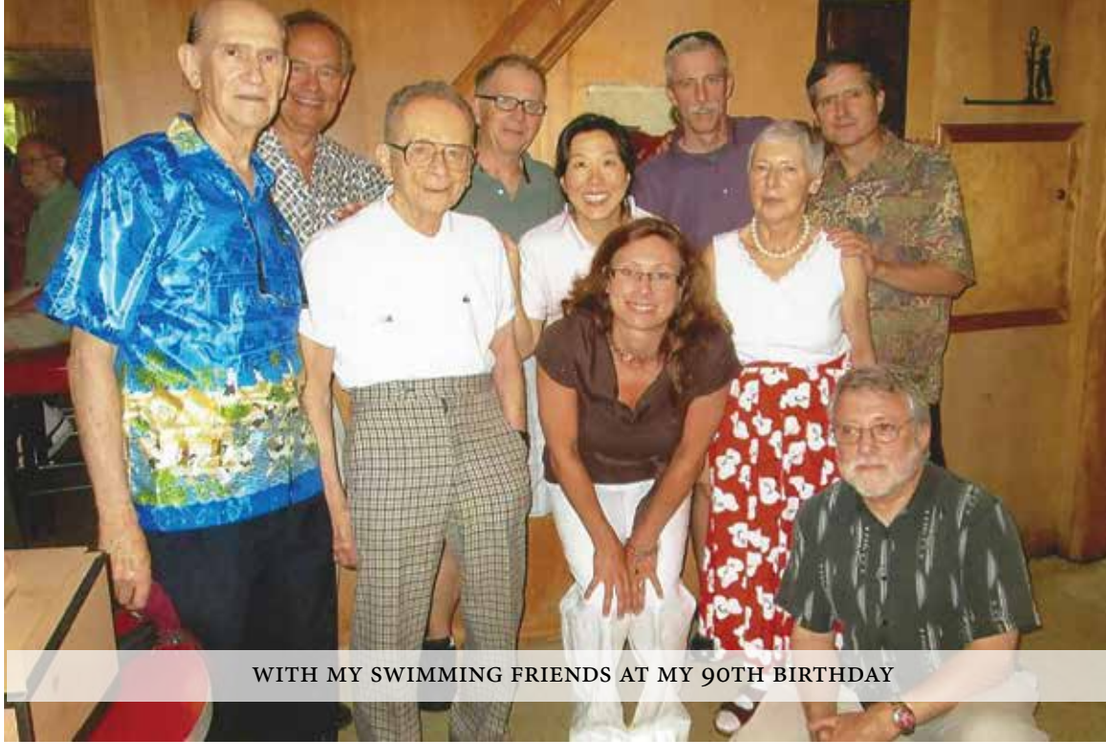
As time has passed and life has changed, I have been lucky to enjoy some great new friendships.

I have made wonderful friends at the YMCA and enjoy my daily swim at 5:30 am. It gives me a sense of community and intellectual stimulation.

BOB MCNEILL

I'll never forget how I met my very very good friend Bob McNeill. He came to the store one day, in the late 1960s, and told me how glad he was that there is a good ski shop in the D.C. area. As we continued our conversation I asked him what he does for living. He smiled and said, "I am a negotiator." I was disappointed. He sounded like such a nice guy, and now he would bargain with me about the price of skis. However, he actually was a negotiator. A trade negotiator for the U.S., who was spending part of each year in Geneva.

We did a lot of skiing and kayaking together, particularly after he stopped skiing in Colorado because of altitude problems. Now he moved to New Hampshire, and I certainly miss him.



WITH MY SWIMMING FRIENDS AT MY 90TH BIRTHDAY

BOB AND ME AT SKI LIBERTY

RUSSIAN FRIEND

A few years after Gert passed away, I met a Russian lady who was a naval engineer. She and her husband worked on a Soviet atomic submarine base in the far north. It was a great job, with long vacations and good pay, but after several years, he was diagnosed with radiation sickness. They moved to Moscow, where he died in less than a year. She got a less challenging job in a Moscow factory. Their only daughter, a computer scientist, worked for an American company in Moscow. She was transferred to the U.S., and settled in Fairfax. Eventually, my friend followed her there.

She would drive to my house almost every Saturday or Sunday, and I would drive her to good restaurants, theaters, movies, etc. She was an interesting person and good company, but then finally I got too old for romance and we parted as good friends.

REFLECTIONS

Now that I have reached the ripe old age of 92, I often reflect on my past, and also on relatives and friends who have passed away. I think how incredibly lucky I have been. Yes, incredible is the right word. I continue to live in my house independently. It is possible because of the support of my family, close friends, and neighbors. My daughter Audrey, who is a college admissions counselor in California, visits me multiple times during the year. She traditionally prepares our delicious Thanksgiving feast.

I love to grocery shop and cook and I am very grateful to my neighbors for their help with my groceries, and looking out for me in general.

The Internet has also played a large role in being able to connect and stay in touch with old friends. I try to keep up with technology. That is how I connected with Monika, who was born in Jasło 50 or more years after me. She lives in Hong Kong and has an uncanny ability to find amazing information. She is a brilliant writer whose letters I treasure.

I also Google things that I am curious about and order off Amazon.

During the warmer months I try to find kayaking partners. I still love to be out on the water and it brings back wonderful memories of my youth. I have treasured the time that I have spent writing and formatting this book with my grandson Michael, because it has given us the opportunity to get to know each other better.

In conclusion, I would like to tell my descendants: Be optimistic. Eventually everything works out. Optimists live longer and enjoy life more. Hope you all will have as lucky and happy life as I did.

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